

FREE PRINTABLE

The Seller's Field Kit

Useful things for the weeks when the deal, the number, or both are giving you trouble.

Some weeks the customer goes quiet, the number looks worse than it did Monday, and your boss wants an update you don't have. This is for those weeks.

No sales methodology here. Just the handful of things I reached for when a quarter was going sideways, and a few I wish I'd reached for sooner. It starts with your number, because most bad weeks start there. **Find the problem you have this week and start there.**

Having a bad week? Start here.

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1. Where your quota came from

Most reps get a number and a kickoff slide and never find out how the number got made. You should, because you can't push back on a number you don't understand, and you can't plan against it either.

At a cloud provider the number almost always starts with prior year revenue, with a growth rate on top. At Amazon that growth rate was usually set above the geo VP. By the time it got to your territory, nobody in your chain had actually picked the number. They just divided it up. SaaS works the same way with different words: last year's ARR or bookings, plus the growth the company promised its board.

Every layer on the way down adds a little cushion. Most sales plans are over-assigned so a few misses don't sink the year, and a common planning rule of thumb is 20 to 30%. It's a big part of why only about half of AEs hit quota while the company still makes its number.

Then find out what your number is measured in, because it changes everything:

- **New bookings or ACV.** Contracts signed. Common in SaaS new business.
- **ARR or MRR growth.** Your run rate at the end of the year against your run rate at the start.
- **Consumption revenue.** What customers actually use, over prior year revenue. A committed contract only counts when the spend shows up.
- **The whole book.** Renewals, expansion and new logos, all together.

Read the comp plan like the contract it is: your on-target earnings, the split between base and variable, your rate (variable divided by quota, which is what every dollar you sell is really worth to you), accelerators above 100%, anything that caps or claws back, and the crediting rules. Who gets credit for a partner deal, a marketplace deal, or an account that moved in June?

If you don't have the plan document, your territory list and prior year revenue for every account you own, ask for all three this week. That's a normal request, and a good manager won't read it as pushing back.

Worksheet: Your plan on one page

Year _____ Online: quotabird.com/quota

YOUR PLAN	WHAT IT SAYS
What the number is measured in	
Prior year revenue: your baseline	
The new number, and the growth it implies	
On-target earnings, and the base : variable split	
Your rate: variable ÷ quota	
Accelerators above 100%	
Caps, clawbacks, thresholds	
Crediting: partners, marketplace, moved accounts	

Anything blank goes on the list for your next one-on-one.

2. Is your quota crazy? Check it, then decide.

Telling your manager "this number is crazy" won't get you anywhere. Bring the math.

Start with the ratio: quota divided by on-target earnings. For SaaS new bookings, 4 to 6 times is a useful working range, and Bridge Group's 2026 median was 4.6. For cloud consumption growth, the plans I've seen mostly land between 15 and 30 times, higher in strategic accounts. That's experience, not a published survey. Quota Check does it in ten seconds.

Then build the case from what you actually know:

- Prior year revenue, minus anything that won't repeat: a one-time migration, a true-up, one giant deal that landed once.
- Your current run rate: this month's MRR times twelve.

- Committed contracts that ramp this year, and how much of them customers will really consume.
- Qualified pipeline at your real win rate.

On a run-rate or whole-book number, add your run rate to the new pipeline you expect to win. On a bookings number, compare last year's bookings, adjusted for headcount, with pipeline at your win rate. Subtract the evidence from the new number. What's left is the gap. Quota Case does the arithmetic.

Now be honest about what can move. The growth rate almost never does. It was set above your manager's boss, and arguing with it just makes you the rep who argued. What can move: the baseline, if it includes revenue that won't repeat; the territory, if accounts moved after the number was set; ramp time, if you're new; and crediting. Pick the one that matters most and ask for that. If you ask for five things, it sounds like complaining.

Then say it plainly: "Here's last year, here's what we're running at, here's what's committed. That leaves a \$1.8M gap I can't explain. What assumption am I missing?"

Sometimes there's a real answer: a new program, a big renewal, a partner with names attached. Then the number is hard but fair. Accept it, get anything that moved in writing, and go to chapter 3.

The best time to shape your quota was last year, while somebody still had the planning spreadsheet open. The next best time is now. Every week you wait, the number gets harder to move and the year gets shorter.

Worksheet: The gap

Date _____ Online: quotabird.com/quota-case

THE EVIDENCE	\$
Prior year revenue	
Minus one-time revenue in it	
Current run rate (MRR × 12)	
Committed contracts landing this year	
Qualified pipeline × win rate	
The new number	
The gap	

My one ask, and who I'm asking

3. It's a tough number. Crush it anyway.

Once the number is set, every week you spend arguing about it is a week you're not building pipeline. The reps I've seen hit tough numbers stopped arguing early and went to work on the gap.

Turn the gap into pipeline: divide it by your win rate. A \$1.8M gap at a 25% win rate is \$7.2M of new qualified pipeline. That's the number to plan around.

It comes from two places, and most years you need both:

- **Growth in accounts you already have.** New workloads, migrations, expansion, renewals with uplift, the second team at a customer who loves the first. Usually faster, because they already trust you.
- **Net-new accounts.** Slower, and the only place the big surprises come from.

Put names next to both. Five existing accounts with a dollar figure and a reason. Five net-new accounts with a reason they'd buy this year. If you can't name them, you don't have a plan yet.

Then start early. On a run-rate number, when a workload lands matters as much as how big it is. A workload that lands in March runs for ten months this year. The same workload in October runs for three. Pipeline you create in Q1 is worth about three times the same pipeline in Q4.

Once a week, look at three numbers: the gap, the new pipeline you created, and your run rate. If the gap isn't shrinking, change what you're working on. Changing the forecast won't close it.

Worksheet: Filling the gap

Gap _____ ÷ win rate _____ = new pipeline needed _____

EXISTING ACCOUNT	WHAT THEY'D ADD	\$	BY WHEN

NET-NEW ACCOUNT	WHY THIS YEAR	\$	FIRST MEETING

4. Is this actually a deal?

Most deals that fall out of the forecast were never really in it. They break in one of five places. Has the customer said, in their words, that they want to solve this? Does the money have a name: a budget line, a program, a fiscal year? Have you met someone who can sign, or just someone who

likes you? Do you know how they'll actually buy it? And what makes it happen this period instead of next?

If you can answer all five with a name and a date, you've got a deal. Otherwise it's still a conversation, and I wouldn't forecast it yet.

Worksheet: Deal inspection

Deal _____ Date _____ Online: quotabird.com/deal

QUESTION	YES / SORT OF / NO	WHO TOLD ME, AND WHEN
Customer: have they said they want to solve this?		
Money: does it have a name and a fiscal year?		
Power: have I met who can make it happen?		
Path: do I know how they'll buy it?		
Now: what makes it happen this period?		

5. You don't have enough pipeline

Everybody repeats 3X. It assumes you win about a third of what you qualify. The honest version is one divided by your own win rate: at 20% you need 5X, at 25% you need 4X.

If you don't know your win rate, count it. Of the qualified deals you had due last year, how much closed, by value? Then count only pipeline that's qualified and due this period against it. Everything else is next year's problem, however real it is.

Worksheet: My pipeline math

Period _____ Online: quotabird.com/pipeline

My number		Closed so far	
Left to close		My win rate	
Coverage I need ($1 \div \text{win rate}$)		Qualified pipeline due this period	
Coverage I have		The gap	

6. Your biggest deal is carrying the quarter

Write your forecast without it. That's closer to your real plan, and if it doesn't work, you need a second way to the number now, before the big one slips.

Then look hard at the big one. Who set the close date, you or the customer? What still has to happen? Two smaller deals you can move are often better than one giant deal you're praying over.

7. You're single-threaded

If your champion disappeared tomorrow, who at the customer would notice the deal was gone? If the answer is nobody, the deal is one reorg away from over.

Ask your contact for one introduction this week, upward or sideways. Most people will say yes if the introduction makes them look good too.

Worksheet: Account map

Account _____ Online: quotabird.com/account

ROLE	NAME	MET?	WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT
Decides			
Pays			
Uses it			
Could block it			
Runs the buying process			
My champion			

8. The customer wants a discount

A discount should buy you something. What comes back? A signature date, more scope, a longer term, a reference you can use. And remember it comes out of your commission at the same rate it comes off the price.

Before you ask your manager to approve it, ask whether the problem is the price or the deal. A discount fixes price. If the real problem is power, path or timing, it just makes the deal cheaper.

9. The deal has gone quiet

Busy and stalled look alike for about a week. Busy looks like short replies and moved meetings. Stalled looks like no replies and nobody else at the customer you can call.

Send one short note that's easy to answer: "Is this still a priority for this quarter, or should I check back in January?" A no is useful. Silence for two weeks after that is an answer too.

10. You're behind the number

Stop treating every deal the same. Three piles: can close, can close with help, can't close this period. Spend your time on the middle pile and tell your manager exactly what help you need.

And if the number itself is the problem, don't just complain about it. Show your manager the math: quotabird.com/notes/prove-the-quota-is-crazy

Worksheet: Quarter rescue plan

Days left _____

DEAL	WHAT HAS TO HAPPEN	WHO DOES IT	BY WHEN

11. Don't make your manager guess

Good managers don't need every detail. They need to know what changed, what might go wrong, and where you need help. "Still feeling good" isn't an update. "Procurement moved the date two weeks, Sarah told me Thursday, and I need you to call her VP" is an update.

Before the forecast call, try to break your own deals the way your manager will. Which of the five from chapter 4 would you defend? Ask for help while there's still time to use it: what you need them to do, and by when.

Worksheet: Manager update

Deal _____ Date _____

What changed

Who told me, and when

What might go wrong

What I need from you, and by when

12. Working back from September 30

The federal fiscal year ends September 30. Most one-year money that isn't obligated by then can't be used for new work, which is why so many federal deals close in September, and why so many slip into October.

The date that matters usually isn't September 30. It's the contracting office's cutoff for getting a package in the door, and many offices set it in the summer so they have time to award. Ask your customer for their office's year-end dates in the spring, not in August.

Then work backward from that cutoff. Before the package goes in, the customer needs the requirement written down, the money identified on a specific line, a way to buy it (a contract vehicle they can use, a task order on an existing contract, or a marketplace purchase), and the approvals lined up. Each of those takes weeks, and none of them is your job, which is exactly why they need dates and names on them.

If the year starts under a continuing resolution, new starts are often on hold until a budget passes. Plan for a slow first quarter and build pipeline anyway.

Put the dates on one page with the customer. If they won't put dates on it, it isn't a September deal yet. Run it through Deal Check.

Worksheet: Working back from September 30

Deal _____ Contracting office cutoff _____ Online: quotabird.com/deal

STEP, LATEST FIRST	DATE	CUSTOMER OWNER	DONE
Award signed			
Package in to the contracting office			
Requirement written down			
Money identified on a specific line			
Buying route agreed			
Approvals lined up			
Technical evaluation finished			

Any blank date is the next conversation with the customer.

Sometimes you just need another set of eyes
A free twenty-minute call, no pitch. · mark@quotabird.com · quotabird.com/about